Case Study: UPI / Online Payment Fraud

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud is a common cybercrime in which attackers trick users into authorizing fraudulent transactions. It usually begins when the victim receives a call, message, or link from someone posing as a bank official, delivery agent, or customer support representative. The attacker creates a sense of urgency, such as claiming a pending refund, prize money, or an account issue that needs immediate attention.

Step-by-step, the fraud typically works like this: First, the scammer contacts the victim and gains their trust using fake credentials or convincing language. Next, they ask the victim to click on a malicious link or request them to “approve” a payment collect request on their UPI app. Many users mistakenly believe they are receiving money, but in reality, they are authorizing a payment. Once the victim enters their UPI PIN, the money is instantly transferred to the attacker’s account, making recovery difficult.

Students, elderly individuals, and people unfamiliar with digital payments are common targets. The consequences include financial loss, stress, loss of trust in digital systems, and sometimes misuse of personal data.

This type of fraud can be prevented by remembering that UPI PIN is only required to send money, not receive it, and by avoiding unknown links or suspicious requests.